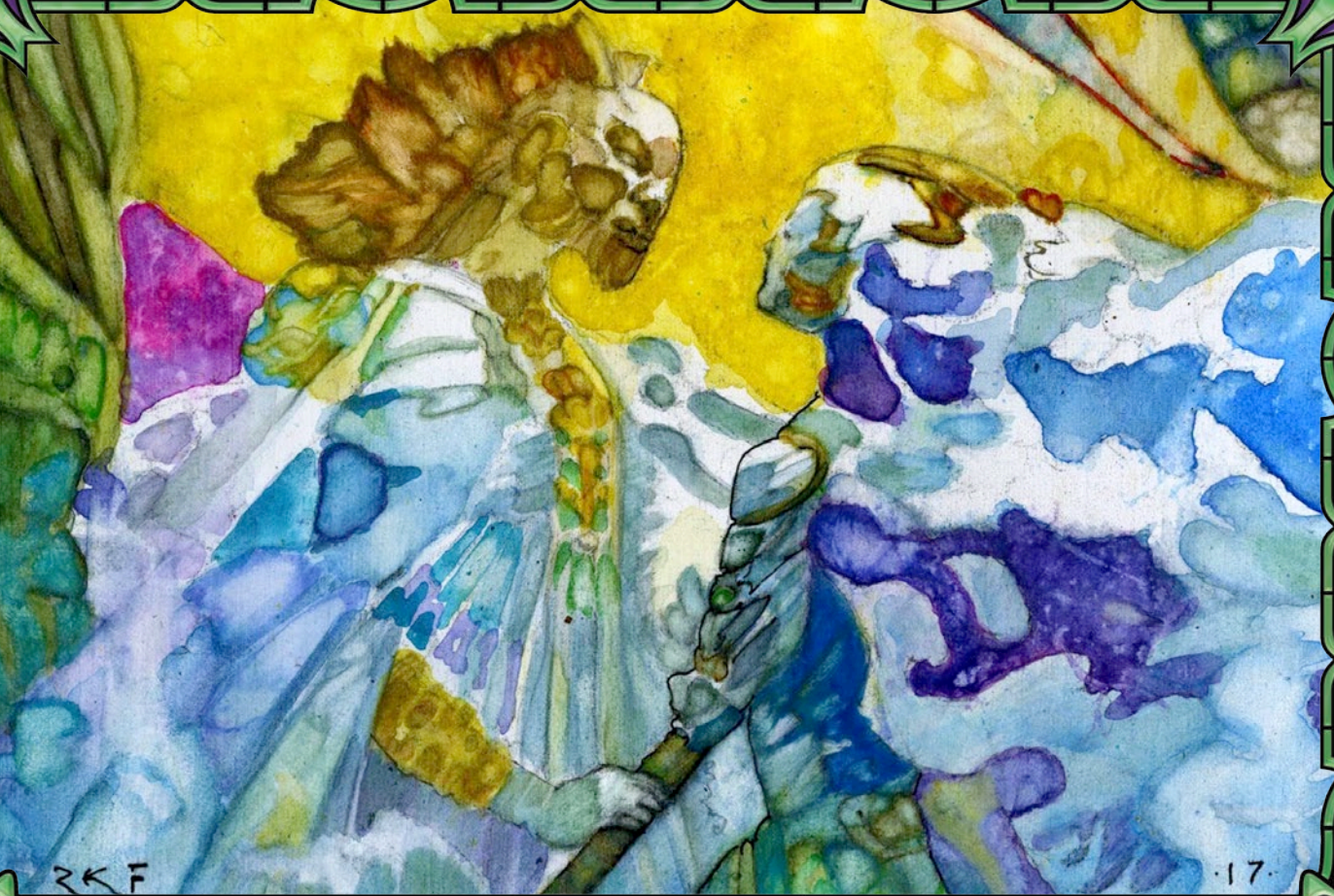




The vassals, Dame Amici, and the other fawning lesser nobles fled the office, leaving Sevastyan alone with his sister. He reached for her with one outstretched arm, pulling her close enough to whisper in his ear if she chose. Zhanna pressed a light kiss high on Sevastyan's cheek. The imprint of her lips burned slightly, hinting at another night with the Daireann lordling. Sevastyan tightened the arm around his sister.

"Tell me," he commanded, his radiant splendor filling the space around him. Zhanna put her lips to his ear and told him.

On the righthand wall of Baron Sevastyan's office, a screw slowly twisted out of a vent cover and fell silently into the plush rug under the baron's desk. Neither Varich sibling noted its fall. Behind the vent cover, two small, black eyes twinkled with accomplishment.

